Bhagyanagar. Yogi was campaigning as part of a phalanx of top BJP leaders, including Amit Shah, J.P. Nadda, Smriti Irani, fronting the BJP's drive to create a new bridgehead in Telangana against the TRS–AIMIM alliance. As he put it, 'Some people were asking me if Hyderabad could become Bhagyanagar. I said, why not? I told them, look, in UP when the BJP government came, we renamed Faizabad as Ayodhya and Allahabad as Prayagraj—where Ganga and Yamuna meet and where the Kumbh is organised—which was its Puranic name. Then why can't Hyderabad be renamed as Bhagyanagar?'[47] The name-change gambit symbolised an extension of the counter-polarisation strategy to new catchment areas in the South.

The BJP had won four crucial Lok Sabha seats in Telangana in 2019—Secunderabad, Nizamabad, Adilabad and Karimnagar. In 2020, the scale of central-leadership firepower that it deployed in a municipal poll in the state capital reflected the party's ambitions of using that initial bridgehead. It aimed to expand in Owaisi's home citadel with a political strategy that had earlier delivered electoral returns in the Hindi heartland as well as in neighbouring Karnataka (see Chapter 15). Yet, in a city where almost every second voter is Muslim, the BJP finished as the second-largest party with forty-eight seats (up from four previously) in the Greater Hyderabad municipal polls. Furthermore, it finished within striking distance of the ruling TRS, which went down drastically to fifty-five seats. Owaisi's AIMIM, fighting in its own bastion , retained its earlier share of forty-four seats. Tellingly, at just two seats, the Congress barely moved the needle.[48] The BJP's meteoric rise in Hyderabad's 2020 municipal poll demonstrated once again the electoral value of Hindu counter-mobilisation. And the increasing irrelevance of the Congress in Muslim-significant areas amid such polarisation.

'Love Jihad' Laws, Political Positioning and the BJP

Two BJP state governments announced plans for a 'love jihad' law in November 2020: UP and Madhya Pradesh. While Madhya Pradesh's planned legislation sought to regulate interfaith marriage with the provision of a five-year jail term for forcible conversion,[49] an